singer was in the ‘kind of situation where he was not approachable with common-sense arguments. I had arranged another discussion between him with the central committee at the time, but it was too late already.’

By this point, Margot’s position in the GDR was formidable. On 18 April 1977, her 50th birthday, the Politburo and the Presidium of the Council of Ministers awarded her the Karl-Marx medal in ‘appreciation of great services to the construction of socialism’.

Nevertheless, to the wider public, her reputation remained poor. It worsened when she introduced compulsory ‘military science lessons’, which focused on air rifle and submachine gun practice, map-reading, tackling assault courses, and the promotion of patriotic thinking. Parents’ despair at the militarisation of youth was exacerbated with the introduction of weekend physical training at military camps. Speaking during a visit to the ‘Pablo Neruda’ secondary school in Oranienburg, Margot Honecker saw for herself how facilities were utilised to ensure a ‘high-standard of military instruction’. According to Neues Deutschland, ‘The girls and boys expressed their readiness to protect and defend the gains of socialism.’19 In a rambling editorial, the paper opined that military instruction offered the best possible prerequisites for acquainting youngsters with the basics of national defence. ‘The young people said that they felt fine in the camp and that their stay was marked by many collective experiences.’20 The church frowned on the scheme, but protests were unsuccessful, thus the arrangement remained compulsory in high schools until 1989.